



PHOTOGRAPHS BY CARLIN STIEHL LOS ANGELES TIMES
PEDRO SANTACRUZ, left, and Emilio Carranza Jr. lead the Joaquin Murrieta ride from Cantua Creek.

COLUMN ONE

3 days. 65 miles. One epic trek honoring a legendary outlaw

For Mexican American riders, this year’s trip feels different

By Clara Harter
REPORTING FROM CANTUA CREEK, CALIF.

For three days and 65 miles, the riders will travel through the heat and dust of the Central Valley to honor a man from the Gold Rush era who, depending on the point of view, was either a freedom fighter or a ruthless criminal.

Their journey begins in Cantua Creek, a rural community in Fresno County, where California Rangers claimed to have shot and killed Joaquin Murrieta in 1853. As proof, they cut off his head and pickled it in a jar.

The nearby California Historical Landmark marker declares Murrieta “a notorious bandit,” but a plaque at the local convenience store hails him as “El Patrio,” the patriot.

“For us Mexican horsemen, he is like our hero,” explains Arturo Barajas, one of those assembling for the journey. “We can’t say he’s a saint, but he’s pretty close.”

The journey is the 46th annual three-day *cabalgata*, or horse pilgrimage, named after the famous Mexican cowboy who once roamed these lands. Blasting mariachi music, Barajas pulls his truck into a field behind the convenience store, where a small group of riders will spend the night. It’s July 24, the eve of the 172nd anniversary of Murrieta’s death.

Although Murrieta was a real person, the events of his life are wrapped in myth.

Legend says he gave stolen gold to poor Latinos after the Mexican territory of Alta California became an American state in 1850, earning him the nickname “the Robin Hood of El Dorado.” His exploits are believed to have inspired the dashing fictional character of Zorro.

For the Joaquin Murrieta riders, he represents someone who stood up against U.S. oppression and demonstrates the

[See Murrieta, A6]



RIDERS cool off in the San Joaquin River on the trip, which ends with a mixed rodeo event.



Despite outcry, L.A. Olympics to press onward

It’s too late for buyer’s remorse, experts say, and few other cities are equipped to host.

By Thuc Nhi Nguyen

The Great Depression threatened the 1932 Olympics. A pandemic raged during the 2021 Tokyo Games. Parisians planned a “poop protest” in the Seine before the 2024 Games.

From natural disasters, construction woes or unpopular opinion, every Olympics has faced threats in the planning process.

Yet nearly every time, the city, ready or not, still hosted the Games.

With less than three years before the Los Angeles Olympics, calls on social media for the city to withdraw or cancel have intensified. Wildfires devastated Pacific Palisades and Altadena in January. L.A. had to balance

Hurdles for city to renege on hosting the 2028 Games:

- Calling off the plans would cause major legal issues because contracts have been signed.
- A city backing out over political issues would be all but unprecedented.
- Los Angeles would face dire financial liabilities, experts say.

a \$1-billion deficit. Immigration raids have put communities on edge while President Trump has threatened further military intervention.

But Olympic preparations press forward. So invested in the success of the 2028 Games, the International Olympic Committee allowed venue naming rights [See Olympics, A8]

CBP agent shoots at men in truck

Family, officers have different accounts of the confrontation in San Bernardino.

By Brittny Mejia and Roger Vincent

From inside the truck, the young man shook his head as federal immigration officers banged on the door and his father repeatedly said in Spanish, “Don’t open it.”

“Francisco! Roll down the window!” one agent said, addressing the father, who was in the driver’s seat.

Another officer smashed the window, shattering it, and Francisco sped away, as three bangs that sounded like gunshots rang out.

The attempt by U.S. Customs and Border Protection officers in San Bernardino to question the men in the truck Saturday morning, captured on video by two of the men, ended with allegations from federal authorities that officers were injured when the driver tried to “run them down.”

“In the course of the incident the suspect drove his truck at the officers and struck two CBP officers with his vehicle,” read a statement from the Department of Homeland Security. Because of that, the official said, a CBP officer discharged his firearm “in self-defense.”

Homeland Security said it was a targeted enforcement operation, which is probably how the officers knew the driver’s name. The department did not answer

[See Shooting, A5]

European leaders to back up Zelensky at Trump meeting

By Samya Kullab and John Leicester

KYIV, Ukraine — European and NATO leaders announced Sunday they will join President Volodymyr Zelensky in Washington for talks with President Trump on ending Russia’s war in Ukraine, with the possibility of U.S. security guarantees now on the negotiating table.

Leaders from Britain, France, Germany, Italy and Finland are rallying around

Zelensky after his exclusion from Trump’s summit on Friday with Russian President Vladimir Putin. Their pledge to be at Zelensky’s side at the White House on Monday is an apparent effort to ensure the meeting goes better than the Ukrainian leader’s last one in February, when Trump berated him in a heated Oval Office encounter.

“The Europeans are very afraid of the Oval Office scene being repeated, and so they want to support Mr. Zelensky to the hilt,” said re-

tired French Gen. Dominique Trinquand, a former head of France’s military mission at the United Nations. “It’s a power struggle and a position of strength that might work with Trump.”

Putin agreed at his summit with Trump in Alaska that the U.S. and its European allies could offer Ukraine a security guarantee resembling the North Atlantic Treaty Organization’s collective defense mandate as part of an eventual deal to

[See Zelensky, A3]



JULIANA YAMADA LOS ANGELES TIMES

VOLUNTEER Sydney holds a stuffed bunny. Teen Line is part of Didi Hirsch Mental Health Services.

Teens step up to help youth mental health

Teen Line, an L.A.-based nonprofit project, aims to fill the gap from federal cuts.

By Corinne Purtill

There are a lot of reasons why people reach out to Teen Line, a Century City-based hotline that connects young people in crisis to trained teenage volunteers.

They call because someone is hurting them or they are afraid of hurting themselves. They text because an important relationship has ended or a troubling conflict has started. They feel disrespected, disregarded, dismissed.

At the heart of almost every call, text or email is the

same cry of pain: Nobody is listening.

So the teenagers on the receiving end do what they wish adults would make time for more often, the thing nobody seems to be doing enough of these days: They listen.

Almost every single time, for at least the length of a call or a chat session, it’s enough.

“Even if their situation is really difficult, the best that we can do at the start is always just to listen,” said volunteer Mendez, 18. (The volunteers’ full names are withheld to protect their privacy and anonymity.) “And even if we don’t have a solution for them, I feel like that is one thing that just helps them so much.”

A project of the Los Angeles-based nonprofit Didi [See Teen Line, A12]

Joshua trees given special protection

By Alex Wigglesworth

California has approved an unprecedented plan to protect the iconic Joshua tree from climate change and development.

The western Joshua tree conservation plan is a broad blueprint that compiles scientific research and traditional ecological knowledge to identify areas where the plant may thrive in a warmer future and plot out how to best protect that land. It recommends limiting development, taking steps to reduce wildfire risk such as culling invasive grasses and introducing Joshua trees with genetic variations that make them more resilient to warming temperatures.

The plan was required by a state law enacted in 2023 and received final approval Wednesday at a Fish and Game Commission meeting. Proponents say the effort is groundbreaking because it seeks to conserve a species that’s abundant now but is projected to lose much of its habitat to climate change.

“This is the first time I’ve ever seen the Legislature and governor take this step to protect a species that may be imperiled in future,” said [See Trees, A12]

Restaurateur Dan Tana dies

His eponymous West Hollywood hot spot is a beloved landmark. Tana was 90 and had retired. CALIFORNIA, B4

‘And Just Like That...,’ so long

Our TV writers bid a bittersweet farewell to the subpar ‘Sex and the City’ reboot. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 85/65. B6



NEWT LIKIER Wetlands and Wildlife Care Center

ON THE MEND

A great horned owl rescued from a glue trap may have a tough rehabilitation because a good Samaritan cut its feathers with scissors. CALIFORNIA, B1



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